



is perfect and are very large and intuitive. Suiting its ultra-compact status, the Shuffle comes with a belt clip that has a good spring that grips well.

Creative's Zen Stone Plus is the next of the really tiny players. It's about the same footprint as the Shuffle, but a little thicker and marginally longer. Creative goes one step further and provides the Zen Stone Plus with a single-colour OLED display. This is a boon for those storing extra music as you can tell what exactly is playing, or which track is next without actually having to listen in. This PMP is very solidly built and has a loudspeaker as well. Creative has got the controls right and although they aren't as good, in terms of feedback, as Apple's controls, they are very well laid out and very intuitive to use. The ergonomics are top class. Unlike the Shuffle, the Zen Stone Plus uses an all-plastic body, but finished in matte texture tones. The quality of plastics used seems very good and in testament to this, the Zen Stone Plus survived (unscathed) a rather nasty drop that occurred during a photo shoot session, where it fell while running from a height of eight feet.

Philips' GoGear SA2825 was one of the more novel designs that we've seen. The body is finished in burnished chrome that looks like a metallic, mirror finish, similar to the finish LG uses on some of its cell phones. It's got a small OLED display, which is covered by a transparent plastic shell. Initially, this shell seemed to fit the player rather loosely and we were wondering if it was removable. We figured out that the shell was a large clickable button with four functions, similar to 4-way joypad keys on cell phones. The screen is reasonably clear, more so than the display on the Zen Stone Plus, and the square-shaped player with slightly rounded edges looks really neat.

The other two players in this category



Apple iPod Shuffle

are from Mitashi. The cheaper of the two is the KNM-2GB that has a really neat looking red-backlit, touch-sensitive array of buttons on the front. It's got a decent LCD display that measures two inches diagonally. The player itself is built pretty well and looks decent with an entire black body. The front is a smooth piano finish, while the rear makes do with a slightly more rugged looking *matte* finish. Using this player can be a pain because the indicated controls for the buttons are not very intuitive and we found that we could not perform some very common tasks without referring to the manual. For example, the middle button will play a highlighted song, but will not pause the track. The pause button is located towards the side of the device. Furthermore, if you've played a track, and then navigate to the track listing, and then press the "Pause" button, you are asked whether you want to delete the song from the track list, instead of pausing the the song that's playing like you'd expect. Such goof-ups are unforgivable, but should be rectifiable via firmware upgrades, which we hope will happen very soon.

The other PMP from Mitashi is the

Sounds bad, smells great

to put MP3 Player along with portable speakers in their perfume bottles.

MWI-4GA, which boasts of a 2.4-inch LCD display – the largest display from among the PMPs in our test. It's a little thick for our tastes, but not enough to call it bulky. The entire body is chromed and this is relieved only by the black-coloured eyelet provided on the top, presumably to strap it to your belt or wrist. There's a loudspeaker vent on the rear. Its buttons are positioned to the right side which is inconvenient. Not only is feedback absent, but the buttons are so recessed into the player that they are actually hard to press – we found ourselves using our nails solely for the purpose of skipping a track, or pausing playback or other common tasks. After a while, your nails begin to hurt from the pressure of using the keys – unforgivable design goof-ups! While still on design flaws, how about the absence of a 3.5-mm stereo jack? The MWI-4GA uses a rare 2.5-mm jack that we're used to seeing in budget CDMA handsets and this, perhaps, is a more unforgivable blunder than the previous one.

Performance

When it comes to performance, none of the other three PMPs can really hold a candle to Apple's tiny Shuffle or Creative's Zen Stone Plus. This does prove our theory that a bigger, costlier player with a display unit does not necessarily equal unbeatable sonic performance. Both these PMPs leave the others far behind in terms of overall music quality and the difference is so noticeable that one did not need the much acclaimed "golden ears" to spot the differences. Both these players do well with the highs, but we noticed a bit of extra treble that could be termed as both brightness when



Mitashi KNM 2GB

Term	Description
Tonal Balance	Degree to which one aspect (read frequency range) of the sonic spectrum is emphasised above the rest
Brightness	A sound that emphasises on the higher frequencies i.e. lower treble or higher mid-range or more
Congested	Smearred, confusing and flat sounding, total absence of soundstage
Crisp	Extended high frequencies, especially cymbals
Detailed	Reproduction of sound where it is easy to hear minute details and nuances
Mid-Range	Audio frequency between 250 Hz and 6000 Hz
Punchy	Good dynamics with strong impact. Typically, used to signify good bass
Soundstage	The area between the left and right channel (or two speakers) that appears to the listener to be occupied by sonic images, similar to a stage concert where different sounds come from different instruments that are placed in different locations.